

# Respiratory Tract Problems



Thyme  
(*Thymus vulgaris*)

The respiratory system stretches from the lining of the eyes and sinuses to the base of the lungs, and is constantly exposed to dust, dirt, and organisms in the air. It is no surprise that in our ever more polluted world we often face problems such as sinus congestion and asthma. Herbal remedies aim to protect the linings of the eyes, ears, sinuses, nose, and throat, as well as the respiratory “tree” of the lungs by countering infection, clearing congestion, soothing the mucous membranes, and relieving inflammation or allergy.

## ❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Difficulty in breathing or chest pain
- Cough that lasts for more than 2 weeks
- Severe pain in the respiratory tract
- Coughing up blood
- Fever of 102°F (39°C) or more
- Heavy nosebleed lasting longer than 1 hour

## 🌿 Coughs & Bronchitis

The act of coughing is usually a reaction to irritant particles in the bronchial tubes. It is worthwhile to consider the type of cough you have and where it is centered. Herbal remedies can then be chosen to work effectively to clear or ease the cough.

**Productive, chest coughs** may produce white, yellow, or green phlegm.

**Unproductive coughs** are dry and irritant and often take a long time to clear.

**Bronchitis** occurs when the lining of the lungs' airways becomes inflamed, resulting in a chest cough, possible breathlessness, and a raised temperature. Use both an external and an internal remedy.

**Herbs** Thyme is an effective antiseptic for the whole system. Licorice acts as a soothing expectorant for persistent coughs and makes any remedy more palatable. Take plenty of garlic to fight bronchitis.

❗ **General caution** Seek professional advice if a cough lasts for more than 1 week without a cold or infection.

### General Remedies

**Herb** Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

**Remedy** Take 3 cups (750 ml) of infusion a day.

### Dry Coughs in the Throat & Chest

**Herbs** Balm of Gilead (*Populus x candicans*, p. 254), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101)

**Remedy** Make an infusion using equal parts of thyme, balm of Gilead buds, and licorice powder. Take ½ cup (75 ml) 6 times a day, or mix equal parts of each tincture and take 1 tsp up to 5 times a day with water. Reduce the dosage as the cough eases.

❗ **Cautions** Seek professional advice if no improvement occurs after 1 week. Do not take licorice if pregnant.

### Chest Coughs & Bronchitis

**Herbs** Elecampane (*Inula helenium*, p. 107), eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96), licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101)

**Remedy (Internal)** Make a decoction of elecampane and take 1¼–1½ cups (300–450 ml) a day. Add 5 g licorice powder to improve flavor.

**Note** For acute bronchitis and coughs, add 5 g of eucalyptus leaf to the decoction.

**Caution** Do not take elecampane during pregnancy.

**Herbs** Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

**Remedy (Internal)** Take ½ tsp of echinacea tincture with water 2–3 times a day, or take tablets. In addition, eat 2 garlic cloves daily.

**Herbs** Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), cajuput (*Melaleuca leucadendron*, p. 234), eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96)

**Remedy (External)** Mix 5 drops each of eucalyptus and thyme essential oils with 2 tsp of olive or sunflower oil. Massage over the chest and back, up to twice a day. Alternatively, burn 5–10 drops of one of the oils in a burner for 30 minutes.

**Caution** Do not apply thyme oil during pregnancy.

## 🌿 Nosebleeds

Many herbs are reputed to stop nosebleeds, and most are effective. Using an herb as snuff is a traditional way of staunching a nosebleed.

❗ **Caution** If the nosebleed continues for some hours or is very heavy, seek immediate professional advice.

### Prevention of Nosebleeds

**Herbs** Eyebright (*Euphrasia* spp., p. 209), nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146)

**Remedy** Make an infusion using 25 g of either herb to 3 cups of water. Take up to 2½ cups a day.

### Nosebleeds

**Herbs** Wild geranium (*Geranium maculatum*, p. 216)

**Remedy** First, pinch the nostrils and tilt back the head. Then sniff ½ tsp of the powdered herb.

## 🌿 Eye Problems

Rather than treating the eyes themselves, these remedies benefit the mucous tissue lining the eyes, which is contiguous with the nose and throat. Problems affecting the linings of the eyes often respond well to local treatment with herbal remedies, but care must be taken not to irritate the eyes with particles of herbs left in the lotion.

### Sore & Tired Eyes

**Herbs** German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), ju hua (*Chrysanthemum x morifolium*, p. 78)

**Remedy** Make a compress by infusing a German chamomile teabag, or make a poultice with 15 g of either herb to 1 cup (250 ml) of water. Cool, squeeze out the excess, and place the teabag or poultice over the eye.

### Conjunctivitis

**Herbs** Eyebright (*Euphrasia officinalis*, p. 209), cornflower (*Centaurea cyanus*, p. 185)

**Remedy** Make an infusion with either herb and strain. When warm (not hot), put in an eye bath and bathe eyes well. Use no more than twice a day.

❗ **Caution** Seek professional advice if there is no improvement in 3–4 days.